



FREE DAD PREP GUIDE

Baby's coming.
Start here.

15 Things Every Dad Should Do Before the Baby Arrives

Practical steps for your head, home, and partnership.
From two dads who remember wondering what to do next.

- 01 Get your head right
- 02 Get your money ready
- 03 Be the partner she needs
- 04 Know what you're walking into
- 05 Decide what kind of dad you want to be



A NOTE FROM JOHN & MIKE

You don't have to do everything tonight.

Finding out you're going to be a dad can bring excitement, fear, and a long list of things you don't know yet. We remember that feeling. This is a place to start.

These actions draw on our experience of becoming dads, including John's twin pregnancy and NICU experience, and Mike's experience when the birth plan changed quickly. They are prompts to use with your partner, not a test you have to pass.

START TONIGHT

Ask your partner: "What would help most this week?"

Choose one task and own it from beginning to end.

Read the section that speaks to what you need next.

Then work through the numbered actions at your own pace. Use the conversation starters together. Leave room for your partner's answers to change what you do.

YOUR FIRST STEP

The task I'll take responsibility for: _____

When I'll do it: _____

This guide shares practical parenting ideas. Your maternity team's advice comes first for questions about pregnancy, birth, or your baby's health. Benefits, insurance, and family planning needs depend on your circumstances.



SECTION 01 / ACTIONS 01 TO 04

Get your head right

You're going through a change too. Give yourself a way to notice what you're feeling and a person you can be honest with.

01 Do a daily check in.

Write one word for how you feel: anxious, excited, overwhelmed, grateful. You can keep it that small. Notice what keeps coming up.

02 Name your biggest stress out loud.

Try: "I've been stressed about ____." Share it with your partner or someone you trust. You don't need to have the answer before you talk about it.

03 Build a reset routine.

Pick something you can realistically return to: a walk, a workout, or ten quiet minutes without your phone. Practice making space for it before baby arrives.

04 Have an honest conversation with another dad.

Tell someone what you're excited or nervous about. Ask what helped them through the early weeks. You don't have to pretend you already know how this works.

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION

"What have you been most stressed about lately? I want to understand."

"What do you need from me emotionally right now?"

KEEP GOING

Further reading: *The Intentional Father* by Jon Tyson. For conversations with John and Mike, visit thedudelaco.com/podcast.



SECTION 02 / ACTIONS 05 TO 07

Get your money ready

Make time to look at the numbers together. The aim is a shared picture of what's coming and a plan for the questions you still need answered.

05 Map both parents' leave on paper.

Check each employer's current policy. Write down leave dates, expected pay, application deadlines, and any income gap. Ask HR to clarify anything you don't understand.

06 Sketch your budget with baby expenses.

Estimate childcare, diapers, feeding supplies, insurance changes, transport, and other essentials. Separate what you know from what you still need to price. Decide together what can wait.

07 Review the family paperwork.

List questions about insurance coverage, beneficiaries, and a will or guardianship plan. Check newborn enrollment deadlines and delivery costs with your insurer. Use qualified advisers for decisions that depend on your family's circumstances.

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION

"Let's look at the numbers together so we know where we stand."

"Which financial task could I take responsibility for this week?"

WRITE DOWN YOUR NEXT CALL

Who: _____ Question: _____

Deadline: _____

KEEP GOING

Start with your employer's benefits portal and your insurer's current plan documents. Further reading: The Family Board Meeting by Jim Sheils.



SECTION 03 / ACTIONS 08 TO 11

Be the partner she needs

Being useful means sharing the work of noticing, planning, and following through. Agree on what matters together, then own your part.

08 Take responsibility for three tasks.

Start with work that needs doing: groceries, dishes, laundry, appointments. Own the whole task. If dinner is yours, that includes planning, shopping, cooking, and cleanup.

09 Ask what would help most right now.

Listen before offering a solution. What helped last month may not help this week. Make a clear plan for the thing your partner actually needs.

10 Pack the hospital bag together, then own the logistics.

Check the birth location's list and your partner's preferences. Gather the supplies, chargers, documents, snacks, and your own essentials. Agree on timing with your maternity team and know where the bag will be.

11 Talk through birth preferences.

Know what matters to your partner and how she wants your support if plans change. Help her ask questions and communicate her wishes. Being her partner does not automatically make you her medical decision maker.

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION

“What do you want me to do if things feel overwhelming?”

“What would help the first week home feel manageable?”

KEEP GOING

Use the Dudela Hospital Bag Checklist. Further reading: Hunt, Gather, Parent by Michaeleen Doucleff. Ask your baby's clinician about safe newborn sleep.



SECTION 04 / ACTIONS 12 TO 13

Know what you're walking into

12 Save the maternity team's contact details.

Ask what changes or symptoms need an urgent call and who to contact outside office hours. Follow their individual guidance. If your partner notices reduced or changed baby movements, contact the maternity team immediately. Do not wait to complete a counting interval or until the next day. [1]

13 Practice asking clear questions.

When time permits, use BRAIN to support a conversation with the care team. Ask about urgency first. This is a discussion prompt, not a reason to delay urgent care.

B / Benefits: What could this help with?

R / Risks: What are the important risks?

A / Alternatives: What other options are available?

I / Intuition: What questions or concerns does my partner have?

N / Nothing: What could happen if we wait, and is waiting safe?

Support your partner's understanding and choices. The care team should discuss options with her; she remains central to decisions about her care. [2]

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION

"At our next appointment, what would you like us to ask?"

KEEP GOING

Ask your maternity team about a childbirth class. Further reading: The Birth Partner by Penny Simkin. Sources [1] and [2] are linked on the last page.



SECTION 05 / ACTIONS 14 TO 15

Decide how you want to show up

You don't need to invent a perfect version of yourself. Start with the kind of relationship you want to build and one habit that supports it.

14 Picture what you want your child to remember.

Finish this sentence: "When my kid is eight, I hope they say their dad ____." Be specific: listened, made time, apologized, stayed present. Put your answer somewhere you will see it.

15 Talk about your family's values.

What do you want home to feel like? How do you want to handle conflict? What do you want to carry forward from your own childhood, and what would you like to do differently?

HAVE THIS CONVERSATION

"What's one thing about us we want to protect after baby comes?"

"What would living that value look like on a tired Tuesday?"

MAKE IT SOMETHING YOU CAN PRACTICE

I want my child to feel: _____

One habit I can start now: _____

Something we want to protect together: _____

These answers can change. Coming back to them helps you decide how you want to show up.



ONE STEP AT A TIME

You can start before you feel ready.

Choose one action. Have one honest conversation. Follow through on one thing. Then come back to this guide when you need your next step.

We made Dudela for the practical help and honest conversations we wanted when we were becoming dads. Keep this guide somewhere you can find it again. You're allowed to keep learning.

John & Mike

WHEN YOU WANT MORE HELP

The Dudela Prep Kit

Six pillars, nine printable tools, and a pregnancy roadmap organized by trimester. A next step when you want more structure.

Explore the \$37 Prep Kit → thedudelaco.com/offers/prep

SOURCES FOR THE CARE CONVERSATIONS

[1] NHS: Your baby's movements.

[2] ACOG Committee Opinion 819: Informed Consent and Shared Decision Making in Obstetrics and Gynecology.

Sources checked September 17, 2026. This guide does not replace your care team's individual advice.